

Stark Shifts in Simulated Excited State Vibrational Spectra

C. Houferak,* E. Rabe,* and J. J. Radler*

Department of Chemistry, University of Washington, Seattle, WA, USA

E-mail: houferak@uw.edu; rabee@uw.edu; jjradler@uw.edu

Abstract

Our chosen system of study is the 2-[(7-4-[N,N-Bis(4-methylphenyl)amino]phenyl-2,1,3-benzothiadiazol-4-yl)methylene]propanedinitrile (DTDCPB) chromophore prevalent in organic photovoltaic materials research. DTDCPB has nitrile groups that make it ideal for IR studies due to its strong signature stretching frequency. For the first component of our project, we hope to simulate some ground state IR spectra of DTDCPB in the presence of varying external fields. This can then be used to calculate the Stark shift and build a calibration curve for the effect of external field on the Stark shift of this molecule. Furthermore, we plan to probe the excited state of DTDCPB as well and see if we can look at Stark effects in the excited state as well. The third step we hope to investigate is a pump-probe transient IR study of this molecule where the excited state dynamics of DTDCPB can be observed. Hopefully our understanding of Stark effects in the ground and excited states will elucidate some of the dynamics of the transient IR study. **CURRENTLY 175 WORDS**

Introduction

As research in solar energy becomes increasingly important for environmental applications, several new strategies are being investigated to increase the efficiency of these devices. Specifically in organic photovoltaics (OPVs), one such strategy has been to use small molecules with large ground-state dipole moments. It is believed that these dipoles can allow for enhanced hole hopping and can minimize charge recombination (ref Griffith). One particularly promising molecule is 2-[(7-4-[N,N-Bis(4-methylphenyl)amino]phenyl-2,1,3-benzothiadiazol-4-yl)methylene] propanedinitrile (DTDCPB) and has resulted in OPVs with power conversion efficiencies of up to 9.6%. The nitrile groups present in the molecule can act as reporter moieties for vibrational spectroscopy. By modeling the effect of an applied electric field on absorption spectrum (Stark Effect), it is then possible to gather information regarding the local electric field during charge transfer events in a photovoltaic device via excited state IR spectroscopy. The first requires a thorough understanding of the electric field dependence of the ground state IR spectrum before probing the excited state.

From a rational materials development standpoint, the ability to understand the mechanisms behind these phenomena enables the tuning and enhancement of current materials in order to create novel, high-efficiency semiconductor and photovoltaic devices. Therefore, computational modeling of these systems is a powerful tool in our kit for developing advanced materials. In this study we use two different computational methods for examining the Stark effect in DTDCPB. Understanding the changes in electronic structure as a result of applied static fields (from the surrounding media in a crystal of DTDCPB) requires the use of models which account for both the electronic structure (quantum mechanical *ab initio* methods) and also the vibrations of nuclei which can be probed experimentally through vibrational spectroscopy.

This study was carried out in several stages. First, the equilibrium properties of the DTDCPB molecule for the ground state were obtained through frequency calculations in *Gaussian 09*. The Stark effect was modeled and calibrated by applying external static electric

fields of various magnitudes to the optimized equilibrium geometries and performing the same frequency calculations as in the model without an applied field. The changes in frequency were obtained from the frequency calculations and compared to calibrate the Stark shifts for the various field strengths. Subsequently, Born-Oppenheimer Molecular Dynamics were used to obtain model spectra using a different set of methods from the standard frequency calculations in *Gaussian 09*.

CURRENTLY 402 WORDS

Theory

Standard Frequency Calculations

First, a brief description of how the *ab initio* frequency calculations are performed in the **g09** distribution of Gaussian is in order.

$$E(Q) = E_0(Q) + \quad (1)$$

The Stark Effect

Discussion of the Stark Effect (what is it, how do we model it?)

Born-Oppenheimer MD (BOMD)

Now some nuts and bolts for how BOMD is performed (Summarize, but with some equations for specifics like in the presentation.)

Specifically, BOMD is able to capture the anharmonicity in nuclear motion, which may only be included in purely *ab initio* calculations by including the third derivative (third order correction) term in the Taylor expansion expression of the energy as a function of nuclear

position and creating an anharmonicity matrix from the system of equations describing the potential energy surface (PES). This is, of course, more computationally expensive than only calculating a first time-derivative of the dipole moment as in BOMD.

The nuclear dynamics calculations needed to simulate vibrational spectra were carried out in various dipole field strengths defined in *Gaussian* in order to “calibrate” the Stark shifts in the product spectra. First the molecular geometry was optimized in *Gaussian* at the *B3LYP/6-311G(d,p)* level of theory in the presence of a static electric field generated by a dipole oriented along the z -axis perpendicular to the plane within which most of the DTDCPB molecule is embedded. Then, thermal sampling is carried out in the same electric field to generate trajectories for nuclear dynamics in a separate job using the optimized geometry.

Obtaining Spectra from Dipole Orientation Time Series

How to calculate spectra from dipole autocorrelation functions vs. how it’s done in the standard frequency calculations (refer to the presentation, but find original references for this...)

METHODS SECTION

Methodology

Overview of the Process

The Stark effect comes in when a field is applied.

Why are we using a static field?

Applied fields to observe Stark shifts

Calibration curve:

Apply external E field

Measure IR spectrum

Calibrate Stark shifts for use in Pump Probe

Watch Charge transfer (local E field)

Easy to put in an external field (molecule comes into Equilibrium in the field) to see the IR

The molecule is geometry optimized, then frequency calculated

Static = x,y,z then value of the field

Geometry optimization in a static E field (google the warnings to explain it)

Include point charges (dummy charges)

Dipole along z-axis, put two point charges on the axis and vary the distance to vary magnitude of the field. Z-axis is normal to the plane of the molecule

In order to efficiently obtain vibrational spectra of the full DTDCPB dimer system and model the experiment BOMD was first applied to a cyanide ion as a test case to coarsely model the nitriles on DTDCPB. Subsequently, it was applied to DTDCPB monomer, and finally to the DTDCPB dimer system. BOMD is an *ab initio* molecular dynamics method which couples quantum mechanical calculation of the electronic structure and potentials to a classical treatment of nuclear dynamics. We chose to use BOMD for the larger molecular systems specifically because it is able to capture more of the physics of the system of interest more efficiently than the traditional method of calculating the Hessian to obtain the

frequency eigenvalues.

RESULTS

Computational Results

DISCUSSION

Discussion

CONCLUSIONS

Conclusion

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Acknowledgements